

The scene and the victim



The scene. Larkhaven is a small riverside town with one famous clock: **Old Lark**, high in the Larkhaven Clock Tower. At its foot stands **Pendleworth & Co. Clockworks**, the old clock shop, where tonight's **Pendleworth Countdown Gala** began at 8:00 pm with punch, sparkling cider, cocoa and a band.

THE VICTIM

Master Clockmaker Ellis Pendleworth kept Old Lark running for forty years. At 10:15 Ellis was due to announce who inherits the keys to Old Lark. Ellis never came out. At 10:28 Ellis was found in the workshop, asleep at the workbench, and could not be woken: something had been added to Ellis's cocoa. The workshop mantel clock had stopped at 9:42.

The investigator. Detective Rowan Hale (played by your host) arrived at 10:45 and has until Old Lark strikes midnight to name the guilty party. Everyone in the shop tonight is a suspect, and every suspect has something to hide.

HOW TO USE THIS LIST

Print one or two copies and leave them on the evidence table. It holds only what everyone at the gala would already know. Booklets 10 to 15 are the core six characters; 16 to 21 are optional and join as more guests arrive.

Core characters



Avery Vale · *Apprentice Clockmaker* CORE

Ellis Pendleworth's apprentice for seven years. Avery knows every gear inside Old Lark, and was the one who found Ellis in the workshop at 10:28. **Costume:** A waistcoat or work apron, rolled-up sleeves.



Parker Brightwell · *Mayor of Larkhaven* CORE

Mayor of Larkhaven for nine years. Parker leads the midnight countdown from the tower steps every year and has big plans for the town's future. **Costume:** A sash or ribbon across the chest, a smart suit or dress.

Core characters

**Reese Calloway** · *Rival Watchmaker from the City* **CORE**

Owner of Calloway Timepieces, the fastest-growing watch firm in the City. Reese came to the gala as a guest of the Mayor. **Costume:** A sleek black outfit, a wristwatch worn over a glove.

**Emerson Quill** · *Reporter, The Larkhaven Ledger* **CORE**

Chief (and only) reporter for *The Larkhaven Ledger*. Emerson came tonight to cover Ellis's big announcement for the New Year's Day edition. **Costume:** A trench coat, a press card tucked into the hat band.

**Harper Lune** · *The Clockmaker's Long-Lost Relative* **CORE**

Arrived on this afternoon's train, introducing themselves as Ellis Pendleworth's long-lost relative. Nobody in Larkhaven had heard of Harper before today. **Costume:** A travel coat, a vintage suitcase or hatbox.

**Devon Ashby** · *Gala Party Planner* **CORE**

Larkhaven's go-to party planner for three years. Devon organised every minute of tonight's gala, from the running order to the photo booth. **Costume:** A sparkly top, a headset or clipboard.

Optional characters

**Kit Sterling** · *Antique Dealer* **OPTIONAL**

Owner of Sterling's Curiosities on the high street. Kit has sold Ellis several antique clocks over the years. **Costume:** Tweed, a pocket square.

**Sage Whitfield** · *Gala Pianist & Bandleader* **OPTIONAL**

Bandleader of the Larkhaven Five and tonight's gala pianist. Sage lives in the little flat above the clock shop. **Costume:** A bow tie or velvet, a touch of sequins.

**Rory Penhallow** · *Keeper of the Clock Tower* **OPTIONAL**

Has kept Larkhaven Clock Tower clean, oiled and locked for twenty years. Rory looks after the tower's time clock, which stamps a card for anyone who climbs. **Costume:** A flat cap, a scarf.

**Blair Okafor** · *Town Historian* **OPTIONAL**

Larkhaven's town historian and keeper of the town archive. Blair is writing the official history of Old Lark. **Costume:** A cardigan, reading glasses.

**Dakota Fenwick** · *Fireworks Master* **OPTIONAL**

Runs Fenwick Fireworks and will light tonight's midnight display from the tower yard. **Costume:** A utility vest, goggles pushed up on the forehead.

**Marley Ashgrove** · *Society Photographer* **OPTIONAL**

Larkhaven's society photographer, running tonight's gala photo booth in the front shop. **Costume:** A beret, a camera on a strap.